

killed. Another victim was Marie-Jeanne Roland, a member of the Girondist faction (a moderate republican group). She was executed for her Girondist sympathies, but her memoirs—written during her time in prison—testified to her bravery and unwavering faith in Enlightenment ideology. The writings of both Roland and de Gouges not only inspired their compatriots but also women across the Atlantic.

Some women, on the other hand, actively supported the radical revolutionary regime that held power from 1792–1795. During the many executions, women known as *tricoteuse*, or knitters, sat beside the guillotine, making objects such as the Phrygian cap, a long-standing symbol of liberty.

Year of revolutions

During the Age of Revolution, rebellions and uprisings also swept Haiti, Serbia, Ireland, and Latin America. The year 1848 saw a wave of revolutions

sweep across Europe. As in earlier revolutions, women came together to form political clubs, advocate for equality, raise money, shelter insurgents, and take part in boycotts. Women in Elberfeld, North Rhine-Westphalia, for example, pledged only to wear clothing purchased in a German state, because their “hearts beat stronger and faster at the hope of a unified Germany.”

Despite contributing to revolutions across Europe and the Americas, women’s actions rarely led to significant changes to their own position. The Code Napoleon—French laws codified after the revolution—denied women most civil and political rights, and the new US Constitution did nothing to improve their status. While revolutionary declarations stated that all men were created equal, it was clear that this ideology did not yet extend to women.

◀ Patriotic blockade

A female rebel leads fellow nationalists as they use furniture to block the waterways of the Rhine during the Baden Revolution of 1849, an uprising to make the Grand Duchy of Baden a republic.

